



Caving and Vertical Caving Trip Leader Qualifications & Checklist:

Aspiring Trip leaders must meet the following requirements to lead Caving & Vertical Caving Trips as either an Assistant Trip Leader or Trip Leader.

Assistant Leader:

- *Possesses current WFA and CPR/AED certifications.*
- *Wilderness First Aid certification*
- *Has completed the Outdoor and Wilderness Leadership course (OWL)*
- *Has been a participant on at least one ROC or OP caving trip.*
- *Has completed Orientation to Cave Rescue (OCR) Course through the National Cave Rescue Commission (NCRC)*
- *An understanding of OP and ROC General and Caving Policies.*

Caving Trip Leader:

- *All the qualifications required for an Assistant Caving Leader*
- *Have participated in at least two ROC or OP Caving Programs as an Assistant Leader.*
- *Approval by the current ECOMM and then OP professional staff*
- *Demonstrates high competency of caving concepts and practices.*

Caving concepts and practices to be demonstrated:

Applicant Demonstrates: (To be assessed on trip)

_____ ☐ *Ability to create and submit a trip sheet to the leader*

_____ ☐ Ability to give appropriate pre trip talk
 _____ ☐ Ability to read and navigate with a cave map
 _____ ☐ Ability to effectively assist participant navigate
 throughout the cave
 _____ ☐ Ability to navigate around bats without disturbing/
 endangering them
 _____ ☐ Ability to help participants experiencing
 claustrophobia.
 _____ ☐ Ability to recognize and manage hypothermia
 _____ ☐ Ability to decide when a handline is appropriate and
 know how to tie it to a secure anchor

Shows Knowledge of: (Can be assessed on or off trip)

_____ ☐ Proper caving clothing.
 _____ ☐ Participant's required equipment
 _____ ☐ Leader's required equipment.
 _____ ☐ Cave Conservation
 _____ ☐ White-nose fungus decontamination
 _____ ☐ Group size regulations
 _____ ☐ Cave specific prohibited activities. (e.g. penetration
 of sumps)

Assistant Vertical Caving Leader:

- All the qualifications required for a Caving Trip Leader
- Have participated in at least one ROC or OP Vertical Caving Program
- Have knowledge and understanding of the techniques taught in a Small Party Assisted Rescue (SPAR) course though the NCRC (or an equivalent)
- Demonstrated knowledge of anchor systems, ascension systems, rappelling techniques, and cave rescue techniques

Vertical Caving concepts and practices to be demonstrated:

- _____ ☐ System Evaluation:
- A commercially manufactured seat harness
 - Two primary gripping points of attachment to the seat harness, one of which should be fully operable with one hand,

- *A tether (or Cowstail) attached to the seat harness ready for use but separate from the primary two gripping points. It may have a locking or non-locking carabiner on the free end,*
- *An approved Decent Control Device (DCD).*

☐ *Ascending:*

- *Be sure to maintain 2 points of gripping attachment throughout your ascent.*
- *Be proficient at ascending. Demonstrate that your system functions properly and efficiently, allowing for a smooth climb.*

☐ *Knot pass on ascent:*

- *Work to pass the knot on first attempt and avoid clipping into the knot.*

☐ *Down-Climb:*

- *Down-climb smoothly without weighting the safety tether*
- *Adjust gripping points of attachment without fully opening cams (preferably by pressing the cam from the top)*
- *Maintain 2 gripping points of attachment throughout the maneuver.*

☐ *Change-Over – Ascent to Rappel:*

- *Perform a change-over correctly and efficiently on 1st attempt without assistance.*
 - *Off-weight the ascender on 1st attempt*
 - *Do not weight the secondary attachment during maneuver*
- *Lock-off of descent device with little to no slippage*
- *Demonstrate control of unlocked descent device before committing to a single point of contact*

☐ *Rappel and knot pass on descent*

- *Rappel in a controlled manner.*
- *Lock and unlock the descender in a controlled manner with little to no slippage*
- *Demonstrate at least one hard lock off during Decent Control Device (DCD) use.*

☐ *Change from Rappel to Ascent:*

- *Perform change-over correctly and efficiently on 1st attempt without assistance.*
 - *Off-weight descender on 1st attempt*
 - *Keep 2 gripping points of attachment during weight transfer to ascending system*

☐ *Personal Protective Equipment (PPE):*

- *Wear helmet at all times in the fall zone and on rope*
- *Wear gloves while handling moving rope*

☐ *Safety:*

- Leaves the fall zone when possible.
- Enter and exits the designated fall zone efficiently.
- Calls "On Rope" and "Off Rope" from outside the designated fall zone.
- Never commits to a single gripping point of contact during the ascent.
- Ideally, do not drop anything while on rope, but call "ROCK!" if you do.

**Taken From: NCRC SPAR Entrance Skill Prep: Personal Vertical System and SRT*

SRT vertical competencies

Vertical Caving Leader:

- All the qualifications required for a Caving Leader
- Have participated in at least two ROC or OP Vertical Caving Programs
- Has passed the Small Party Assisted Rescue (SPAR) course through the NCRC (or an equivalent)
- Approval by the current ECOMM and then OP professional staff.

Certifications:

Name	Date/Exp.
_____	☐ WFA Certification
_____	☐ CPR Course
_____	☐ OWL Course
_____	☐ Orientation to Cave Rescue (OCR) or approved higher
level course	
_____	☐ Small Party Assisted Rescue (SPAR) Certification.

The trainee has demonstrated all the proper knowledge and skills and has now been approved by the executive committee and OP Professional staff. They are now considered a caving or vertical leader and is aware of the responsibilities and risks associated with leading trips.

New Leader Name (Printed)

RIN

New Leader Signature

Date

Executive Committee Member

Date

Outdoor Programs Signature

Date